No Tricks, Just Clear Steps — SSI, SSDI & DAC Basics for Families

KEY NOTES — Jessica's presenter cheat sheet • Friday, October 30, 2026 • 6:30–7:15 PM CT • Free Zoom class • Southern Oak Financial & Wellness

Your opening line: “Applying for Social Security benefits can feel confusing, scary, and overwhelming. Tonight we slow it down — plain words, clear steps, no tricks.”

The three benefits — simple-words definitions

SSI (Supplemental Security Income): The NEED benefit. A monthly benefit for a child or young adult with a disability, when the family has limited income and limited savings. Nobody has to have worked for this one.

SSDI (Social Security Disability Insurance): The WORK benefit. For a young adult (about 18–26) who worked and paid Social Security taxes, and now cannot work because of a disability. Needs enough work credits — young workers need fewer.

DAC (Disabled Adult Child benefits): The PARENT'S-RECORD benefit. Despite the name, it is for ADULTS whose disability began before age 22. It pays on a parent's work record when the parent retires, becomes disabled, or has died. The adult child usually must be unmarried.

Who qualifies — quick table

Program	Who it's for	The tests
SSI	Child or young adult with a disability; family income and savings are limited	Disability test + money test (parents' income counts — “deeming”)
SSDI	Young adult 18–26 who worked and paid into Social Security	Disability test + work credits test (their own work)
DAC	Adult whose disability began before age 22; a parent has retired, become disabled, or died	Disability test + parent's work record; usually must be unmarried

Key points by topic

The two tests (every program): Disability test + money/work test. Pass BOTH or the answer is no — even if the other test is strong.

Disability test, plain words: “Marked and severe” = the condition limits everyday life in a big way (learning, talking, moving, playing, self-care) and will last at least 12 months. A diagnosis alone is not enough — what it does to daily life decides it. Records are the proof.

Money / work test, plain words: SSI: part of the parents' pay counts for a child at home (“deeming”); savings count too. Home and usually one car do NOT count. SSDI: the young adult's own work credits. DAC: the parent's work record.

First steps to file: Call Social Security at 1-800-772-1213 (child claims start by phone or at the local office; adults can also start online at ssa.gov). The first contact day is the “protective filing date” — benefits only count from that date. SAVE the Reference number.

Papers to gather: Birth certificate + Social Security card; pay stubs; bank statements; a list of EVERY doctor, clinic, hospital, and therapist with dates; school reports; ID and proof of address. One folder for everything.

Tips that help a filing: Keep copies of everything. Write down names and dates from every call. Open SSA mail the day it comes — appeal deadlines are usually 60 days. Keep every doctor appointment: no visits = no records = no proof. A first “no” is common — many families win on appeal.

3 mistakes that hurt families: 1) Waiting to apply (the filing date cannot move back). 2) Missing mail and deadlines (a missed 60-day appeal can mean starting over). 3) Stopping doctor visits (no records, no proof).

Likely parent questions — one-line answers

“My child has a diagnosis. Does that mean they qualify?” Not by itself. Social Security looks at how the condition limits everyday life — and the family must also pass the money or work test.

“We both work. Can our child still get SSI?” Maybe. Only part of your pay counts for a child at home. Social Security runs the real numbers after you apply — don't count yourself out first.

“How much would the benefit be?” It depends on your family's income and situation, and Social Security figures it after you apply. Tonight I can show you how to start the claim the right way.

“My son is 24 and has never worked. Is there anything for him?” Two doors to look at: SSI, which is based on need — and DAC later, if his disability began before age 22 and a parent retires, becomes disabled, or has died.

“We were denied. Is it over?” Usually not. You can appeal — the deadline is usually 60 days from the date on the letter, so act fast. Keep the doctor visits going; new records are new proof.

“Do you file the application for us?” You file — Social Security requires it to come from you. I guide you step by step on Zoom, so you never sit at the table alone wondering what a question means.

Your closing next step (say it word for word)

“If this class helped you, do two things tonight. One: book your FREE consultation at southernoakfw.org/book — we meet by Zoom, in English or Spanish, and we look at which benefit fits your family and your very next step. Two: tell one parent you know — families find help through other families. Remember: file early, open the mail, keep the appointments. You do not have to do this alone.” • Email: southernoakfw@gmail.com • Serving San Antonio, the Rio Grande Valley & surrounding cities

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